BRIEFING · HALLOWEEN, FOOD WASTE AND THE PUBLIC REALM

Carved, binned and smashed: the full cost of Halloween pumpkins in Northern Ireland

Northern Ireland is the home of Halloween, and that is worth protecting. But the week after 31 October has a cost nobody counts: about 425,000 uneaten pumpkins, 900 tonnes of food, tens of tonnes of seed, easy meals for rats, sick hedgehogs and pulp on the pavements. The answer is not a no-fun council. It is to design the after-party.

IN NUMBERS

818,000
pumpkins bought for carving in NI each Halloween (estimate)

425,000
never eaten: about 52%, or ~911 tonnes of edible flesh

£0.72–0.79m
of household food spending thrown away; ~2.6m meals forgone

21–41 t
of edible seed binned, worth £166k–£491k at UK seed prices

66,000+
pest reports to NI councils and NIHE since 2020 (BBC News NI)

~14%
post-Halloween rise in household food waste over a normal fortnight

FINDING 1
FOOD AND MONEY

Half the pumpkins we buy are never eaten

No one counts Halloween pumpkins in Northern Ireland. Scaling Hubbub's UK survey (30.43m bought for carving, 15.82m not eaten, worth £26.7m) by NI's 2.7% share of UK households gives about 818,000 pumpkins bought and 425,000 binned. NI households spend roughly £1.4m on carving pumpkins and throw away about half of that. Around 41% of people are unsure whether 'carving pumpkins' are food. They are.

Around 911 tonnes of extra organic waste reaches council collections in early November, about 14% above a normal fortnight (WRAP puts NI household food waste at 164,000 tonnes a year). Somerset Council measured a 19% post-Halloween rise. These are conservative figures: Halloween is bigger here than in most of Britain.

FINDING 2
LOST SEED

The forgotten crop inside every lantern

A carving pumpkin holds two-thirds to one cup of seed, about 50 g dried. Most of it is scooped straight into the bin.

MEASURE	SEED FROM UNEATEN PUMPKINS ONLY	SEED FROM EVERY CARVED PUMPKIN
Weight	~21 tonnes	~41 tonnes
Value (£7.80–£12/kg)	~£166k	~£491k
28 g handfuls	~0.8 million	~1.5 million
Protein	~4 tonnes	~8 tonnes

The uneaten pumpkins alone hold about 210 million seeds. Many carving varieties are F1 hybrids that will not grow true, but saved seed still suits school and community growing. Oven-dried, unsalted and crushed, it makes good winter bird food (RSPB).

FINDING 3
RATS

An easy meal at the start of the cold season

Halloween falls just as rodents move towards homes for food and shelter. The British Pest Control Association and the National Pest Technicians Association warn that doorstep pumpkins, especially once they soften and rot, attract rats and mice, which carry Salmonella, Listeria and Leptospirosis. Pumpkins dumped in urban green space do the same.

NI's system is already stretched. BBC News NI counted more than 66,000 pest reports to councils and the Housing Executive since 2020, over 23,000 of them in Belfast. Only Belfast offers a free pest control service; most councils give advice only. Rentokil reports large regional spikes in NI rodent activity. Pumpkins do not cause infestations on their own, but a week of free food is the wrong signal to send.

FINDING 4
BIRDS, HEDGEHOGS, WOODS

"Leaving it for the wildlife" does more harm than good

- **Hedgehogs:** pumpkin flesh causes diarrhoea and dehydration, and rotten pumpkin can cause fatal infection, just as hedgehogs must gain weight to survive hibernation.
- **Woodland:** the Woodland Trust says dumped pumpkins damage sensitive soils, plants and fungi, attract rats, and can spread disease among deer, foxes, badgers and birds.
- **Birds:** birds can benefit if it is done properly. The RSPB's pumpkin feeder sits high, out of hedgehog reach, and is cleared once it rots. Never put out salted or spiced seed.

FINDING 5
PUBLIC REALM

Pulp on the pavement, pumpkins in the park

- **Smashing:** smashed pumpkins, egging and bottles are part of the Halloween antisocial behaviour some Belfast neighbourhoods report each year. Pulp is a slip hazard; Staffordshire's rangers found rotting pumpkins making park paths dangerous.
- **Dumping:** pumpkins left in parks, woods and verges are litter under the Litter (Northern Ireland) Order 1994, as amended by the Clean Neighbourhoods and Environment Act (NI) 2011, with a default fixed penalty of £75. Fining well-meaning families is neither practical nor desirable, but someone pays to clear up.
- **Hidden cost:** councils absorb event clean-ups in standing budgets. Belfast's citywide street cleansing budget is about £13.8m.
- **Civic displays:** Belfast City Hall has hosted pumpkin patches of 1,000+ pumpkins. Displays like these could show what good disposal looks like.

APPROACH

Not a 'no-fun council'

A list of 'don'ts' backed by fines gets the economics backwards. Derry Halloween, Europe's largest Halloween festival and 40 this year, draws around 120,000 visitors and is reported to add about £7.4m to the local economy. The island-wide Home of Halloween programme supported 830+ events and 322,000 visitors in 2025.

> Design the after-party, not the ban. The energy that carves the pumpkin can eat, share and compost it. Leicester's annual community Pumpkin Smash, where families bring lanterns to an allotment to smash and compost, turns the clean-up into the fun part.
>
> CARVE IT · COOK IT · EAT IT · COMPOST IT

RECOMMENDATIONS

What would work

- **Pumpkin Smash days** on the first weekend of November in council parks, allotments and community gardens, with compost bays and seed-roasting stalls.
- **A one-off kerbside pumpkin collection** beside the food caddy, with candles removed, as several GB councils already offer.
- **Seed in schools:** roast-and-taste sessions and seed-saving for spring planting.
- **Honest labelling:** retailers stop implying carving pumpkins are not food, and add a recipe at the point of sale.
- **One wildlife message** agreed by DAERA, the RSPB, Ulster Wildlife and councils: feeders high, seeds unsalted, nothing in the woods.
- **Councils lead by example:** every civic display ends in a public smash or a donation to a composting scheme.
- **Measure it:** add a Halloween question to WRAP's NI Household Food Management Survey, and have councils record the post-Halloween food-waste uplift, cleansing effort and pest calls.

Policy hook. The pumpkin is a small, concrete case of a bigger public realm question: who plans for the aftermath of popular seasonal events in shared space? NI councils already hold the litter, cleansing and food-waste powers. What is missing is an expectation to plan positive, low-waste use of the public realm around major festivals. Environmental and local government matters here are devolved to the NI Assembly.

METHOD

NI share = 768,810 households (NISRA, Census 2021) ÷ 28.6m UK households (ONS, 2024) = 2.69%, applied to Hubbub's 2023 UK totals, which councils still quoted in 2025. Weight of 2.1 kg per pumpkin from Powys County Council (63,000 pumpkins, 135 t); six meals per pumpkin from Hubbub. Value range uses Hubbub's implied £1.69 per pumpkin and a 2026 nine-supermarket average of £1.85 (Fast Loan UK via Grocery Gazette; indicative). Seed: ~50 g dried per pumpkin (2/3–1 cup; USDA 64 g/cup), protein 5.3 g per 28 g (USDA), priced at UK wholesale £7.80/kg and Tesco £12/kg. Hubbub's data rest on a 2,000-person online UK survey, so NI estimates carry wide uncertainty (±30%). Rat, wildlife and public realm impacts are not monetised, because no NI data tie them to pumpkins specifically.

Sources. Hubbub, Eat Your Pumpkin (Oct 2023) · NISRA Census 2021 · ONS, Families and households in the UK: 2024 · WRAP, Household Food and Drink Waste in NI 2021-22 · Powys CC; Somerset Council · Grocery Gazette, 15 Oct 2026 · BPCA, 23 Oct 2025; NPTA via Express & Star · BBC News NI pest data; Rentokil via STV · Woodland Trust; RSPB; Countryfile · Staffordshire CC; Belfast Live · Litter (NI) Order 1994; Clean Neighbourhoods and Environment Act (NI) 2011 (legislation.gov.uk) · Irish News; Belfast Media · Tourism NI, 21 Jul 2026 · Leicestershire CC, Pumpkin Smash.

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